

The Bet

Anton Chekhov · 1889

First published: tr. Constance Garnett, 1915–1920

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Bet_and_Other_Stories/The_Bet (revision 7093575), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Bet suggest about the value of life?
- What does The Bet suggest about knowledge and renunciation?
- What does The Bet suggest about money and freedom?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Bet	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*the value of life* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Bet

Focus: what fifteen years of solitude teach

Content note (contemplated murder): Sensitive content: Contemplated murder. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes contemplated murder.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

At a party a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot stay fifteen years in solitary confinement. The lawyer reads everything, from stories to languages and theology. On the eve of the end the ruined banker plans to kill him, but finds a letter renouncing the money and all worldly goods as vanity. The lawyer escapes five hours early, forfeiting; the banker locks the letter in his safe.

Background: Written 1889. Translation used: S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry, The Bet and Other Stories (1915), public domain in the US.

Significance: Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes contemplated murder.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are unwearying, emaciation, bartered, erudite, zealously. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull." In this sentence it means: never tiring. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Bet would have known. Written 1889. Translation used: S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry, The Bet and Other Stories (1915), public domain in the US. Why does this story matter? Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: ""Why did I make this bet?" I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to what fifteen years of solitude teach? I circle "caprice", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *"Why did I make this bet? What's the good? The lawyer loses fifteen years of his life and I throw away two millions. Will it convince people that capital punishment is worse or better than imprisonment for life. No, No! All stuff and rubbish. On my part, it was the caprice of a well-fed man; on the lawyer's, pure greed of gold."*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Structure, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Bet develops the idea of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim. Read in the public-domain translation by S. S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to the value of life? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about what fifteen years of solitude teach, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes what fifteen years of solitude teach. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
unwearying (adjective)	never tiring	*All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
emaciation (noun)	extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food	*His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bartered (verb)	traded goods or things of value instead of using money	*So do I marvel at you, who have bartered heaven for earth.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
erudite (adjective)	having or showing great learning	*The banker found it strange that a man who in four years had mastered six hundred erudite volumes, should have spent nearly a year in reading one book, easy to understand and by no means thick.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
zealously (adverb)	in a zealous manner	*In the second half of the sixth year, the prisoner began zealously to study languages, philosophy, and history.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
caprice (noun)	a tendency to change one's mind suddenly	*On my part, it was the caprice of a well-fed man; on the lawyer's, pure greed of gold."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
communicate (verb)	transmit information	*By the agreement he could communicate, but only in silence, with the outside world through a little window specially constructed for this purpose.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
visited (verb)	called on (someone)	*And beautiful women, like clouds ethereal, created by the magic of your poets' genius, visited me by night and whispered me wonderful tales, which made my head drunken.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the value of life?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What starts the bet? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment
2. How long must the lawyer stay confined? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Fifteen years
3. What is the prize? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Two million rubles
4. Why does the banker plan to kill the lawyer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Paying would ruin him
5. What does the lawyer do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Renounces the money and leaves early
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Bet" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: At a party a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot stay fifteen years in solitary confinement. The lawyer reads everything, from stories to languages and theology. On the eve of the end the ruined banker plans to kill him, but finds a letter renouncing the money and all worldly goods as vanity. The lawyer escapes five hours early, forfeiting; the banker locks the letter in…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Bet"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Bet" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull." What does "unwearying" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: unwearying: never tiring.
10. Reread: "His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old." What does "emaciation" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: emaciation: extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Bet” suggest about what fifteen years of solitude teach? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the structure in this story shape what we understand about what fifteen years of solitude teach? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. In the passage that begins “"Why did I make this bet?”, why might Chekhov have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Bet”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: At a party a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot stay fifteen years in solitary confinement. The lawyer reads everything, from stories to languages and theology. On the eve of the end the ruined banker plans to kill him, but finds a letter renouncing the money and all…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Bet” set up that the rest of The Bet will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the value of life? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Written 1889. Translation used: S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry, The Bet and Other Stories (1915), public domain in the US. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

3. Rewrite one moment of "The Bet" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about what fifteen years of solitude teach? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Bet": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to knowledge and renunciation: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Chekhov need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Bet" treats what fifteen years of solitude teach with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Bet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the value of life? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about what fifteen years of solitude teach? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Anton Chekhov about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Structure**: how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. What starts the bet?
   A. A business deal
   B. An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment
   C. A card game
   D. A dare about fasting
2. How long must the lawyer stay confined?
   A. Ten years
   B. Fifteen years
   C. Five years
   D. Twenty years

3. What is the prize?
   A. Two million rubles
   B. A house
   C. A marriage
   D. A pardon
4. Why does the banker plan to kill the lawyer?
   A. The lawyer escaped
   B. Paying would ruin him
   C. Revenge
   D. Jealousy
5. What does the lawyer do at the end?
   A. Stays longer
   B. Dies
   C. Claims the money
   D. Renounces the money and leaves early
6. In the line "All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.", what does "unwearying" most nearly mean?
   A. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   B. never tiring
   C. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
   D. having or showing great learning
7. In the line "His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old.", what does "emaciation" most nearly mean?
   A. having or showing great learning
   B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   C. never tiring
   D. traded goods or things of value instead of using money

Answer key: 1. B (An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment); 2. B (Fifteen years); 3. A (Two million rubles); 4. B (Paying would ruin him); 5. D (Renounces the money and leaves early); 6. B (never tiring); 7. B (extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Bet," how does Chekhov show what fifteen years of solitude teach? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Bet, how does Chekhov develop the idea of what fifteen years of solitude teach? State a clear claim, support it

with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea. Read in the public-domain translation by S. S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Bet develops the idea of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim. Read in the public-domain translation by S. S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Bet (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Bet suggests about what fifteen years of solitude teach. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and structure), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Anton Chekhov uses irony in The Bet to complicate the reader's understanding of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Bet within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of what fifteen years of solitude teach responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Bet alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of what fifteen years of solitude teach follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Bet and its treatment of what fifteen years of solitude teach. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and structure, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Bet as evidence for a larger claim about what fifteen years of solitude teach in The Bet. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Bet as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Bet.

SAT-style questions

1. *So do I marvel at you, who have bartered heaven for earth.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “bartered” most nearly mean?

   A. a tendency to change one's mind suddenly

   B. traded goods or things of value instead of using money

   C. called on (someone)

   D. transmit information

2. *"Why did I make this bet? What's the good? The lawyer loses fifteen years of his life and I throw away two millions. Will it convince people that capital punishment is worse or better than imprisonment for life. No, No! All stuff and rubbish. On my part, it was the caprice of a well-fed man; on the lawyer's, pure greed of gold."*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Bet”?

   A. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

   B. A story so convincing it becomes real

   C. What fifteen years of solitude teach

   D. Confinement driving a woman into madness

SAT key: 1. B (traded goods or things of value instead of using money); 2. C (What fifteen years of solitude teach)

Whole-book test

The Bet: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What starts the bet?
   A. A business deal
   B. An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment
   C. A card game
   D. A dare about fasting
2. How long must the lawyer stay confined?
   A. Ten years
   B. Fifteen years
   C. Five years
   D. Twenty years
3. What is the prize?
   A. Two million rubles
   B. A house
   C. A marriage
   D. A pardon
4. Why does the banker plan to kill the lawyer?
   A. The lawyer escaped
   B. Paying would ruin him
   C. Revenge
   D. Jealousy
5. What does the lawyer do at the end?
   A. Stays longer
   B. Dies
   C. Claims the money
   D. Renounces the money and leaves early
6. In the line “All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.”, what does “unwearying” most nearly mean?
   A. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   B. never tiring
   C. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
   D. having or showing great learning

7. In the line “His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old.”, what does “emaciation” most nearly mean?
   A. having or showing great learning
   B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   C. never tiring
   D. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
8. As used in the story (“All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.”), what does “unwearying” mean?
   A. never tiring
   B. in a zealous manner
   C. called on (someone)
   D. having or showing great learning
9. As used in the story (“His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only f”), what does “emaciation” mean?
   A. a tendency to change one's mind suddenly
   B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   C. never tiring
   D. in a zealous manner
10. As used in the story (“So do I marvel at you, who have bartered heaven for earth.”), what does “bartered” mean?
    A. transmit information
    B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
    C. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
    D. a tendency to change one's mind suddenly
11. As used in the story (“The banker found it strange that a man who in four years had mastered six hundred erudite volumes, should have spent nearly a year in readin”), what does “erudite” mean?
    A. called on (someone)
    B. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
    C. transmit information
    D. having or showing great learning
12. As used in the story (“In the second half of the sixth year, the prisoner began zealously to study languages, philosophy, and history.”), what does “zealously” mean?
    A. in a zealous manner
    B. never tiring
    C. having or showing great learning
    D. called on (someone)

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how the value of life develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how knowledge and renunciation develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how money and freedom develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (the value of life, knowledge and renunciation, money and freedom) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment); 2. B (Fifteen years); 3. A (Two million rubles); 4. B (Paying would ruin him); 5. D (Renounces the money and leaves early); 6. B (never tiring); 7. B (extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food); 8. A (never tiring); 9. B (extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food); 10. C (traded goods or things of value instead of using money); 11. D (having or showing great learning); 12. A (in a zealous manner)

Essay assignments

Essay: The value of life

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bet teaches about the value of life. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Anton Chekhov develops the value of life in The Bet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Anton Chekhov develops the value of life across The Bet. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the value of life. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the value of life in The Bet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Anton Chekhov's choices in The Bet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the value of life, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bet's treatment of the value of life in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the value of life in The Bet that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the value of life in The Bet. Name your critical method, apply it

closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the value of life in The Bet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the value of life in The Bet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Knowledge and renunciation

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bet teaches about knowledge and renunciation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Anton Chekhov develops knowledge and renunciation in The Bet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Anton Chekhov develops knowledge and renunciation across The Bet. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of knowledge and renunciation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of knowledge and renunciation in The Bet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Anton Chekhov's choices in The Bet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of knowledge and renunciation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bet's treatment of knowledge and renunciation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on knowledge and renunciation in The Bet that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on knowledge and renunciation in The Bet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about knowledge and renunciation in The Bet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on knowledge and renunciation in The Bet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Money and freedom

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bet teaches about money and freedom. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Anton Chekhov develops money and freedom in The Bet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Anton Chekhov develops money and freedom across The Bet. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of money and freedom. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of money and freedom in The Bet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Anton Chekhov's choices in The Bet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of money and freedom, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bet's treatment of money and freedom in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on money and freedom in The Bet that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on money and freedom in The Bet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about money and freedom in The Bet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on money and freedom in The Bet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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